

The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Global Data, 2023 | IHME Global Burden of Disease

Source: Our World in Data — Saloni Dattani, Lucas Rodés-Guirao, Hannah Ritchie, and Max Roser (2023)

Hundreds of Millions Affected: The Scale of Major Depression

WOMEN

1 in 3

will experience major depression
in their lifetime

MEN

1 in 5

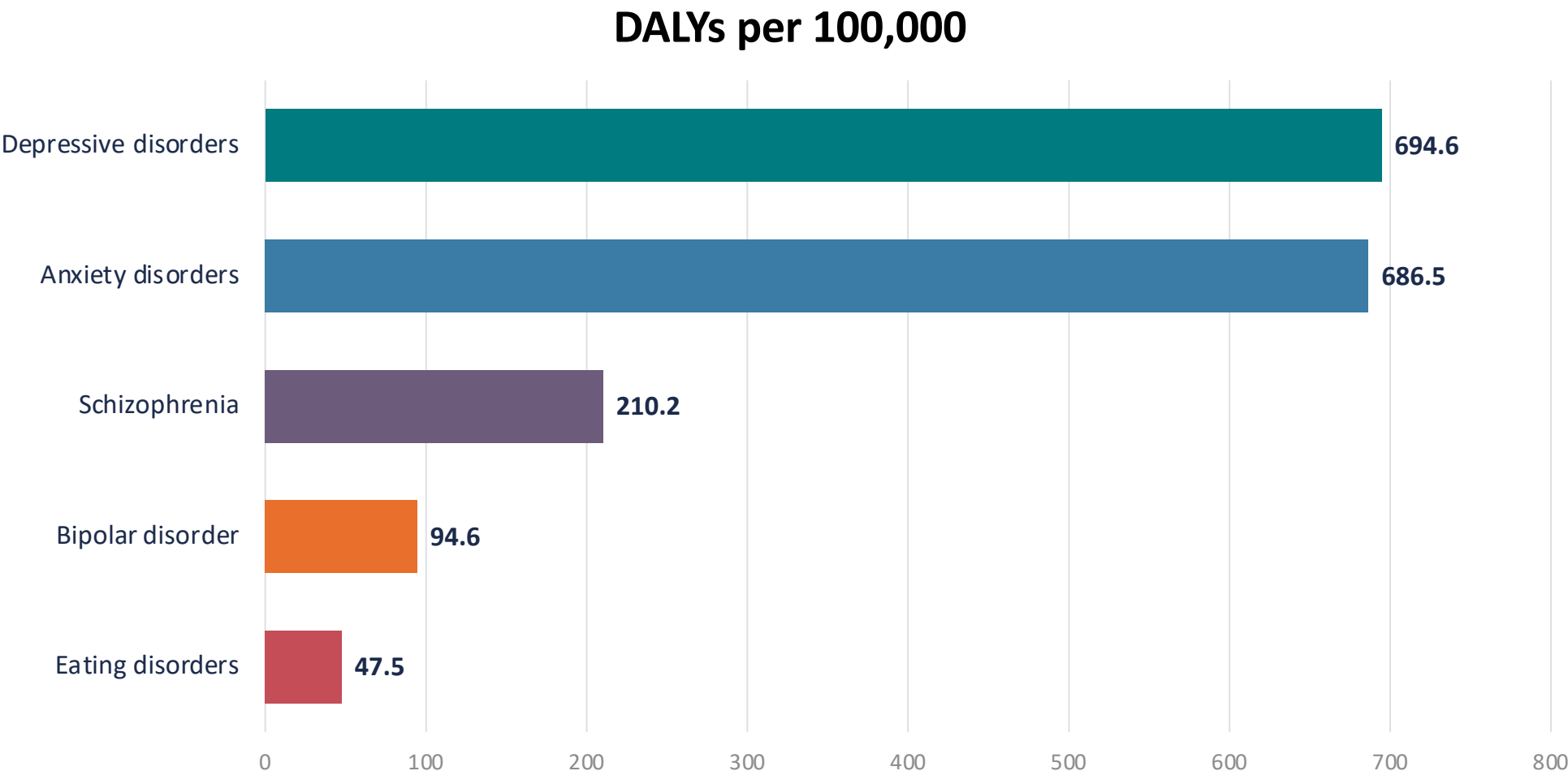
will experience major depression
in their lifetime

Mental health conditions span from common disorders (depression, anxiety) to less common but severe conditions (schizophrenia, bipolar disorder).

These figures underscore why mental health must be a policy priority — the population-level impact is enormous.

Depression and Anxiety Dominate the Global Mental Health Burden

DALYs per 100,000 people — World, 2023 | Source: IHME, Global Burden of Disease

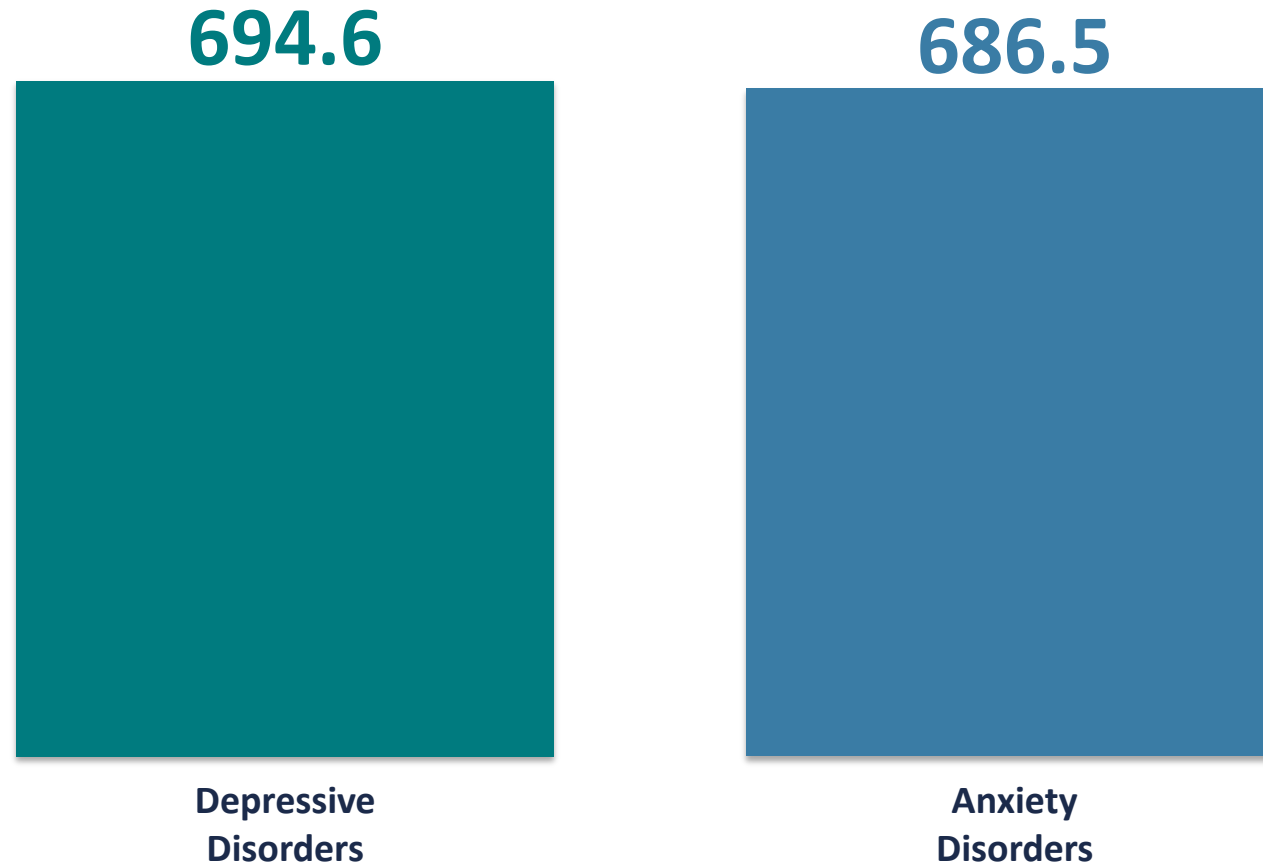


Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Disease Burden

DALYs per 100,000 people

Combined, depression and anxiety account for ~80% of the total mental health disease burden across the five major categories.

The difference is just 8.1 DALYs — effectively a statistical tie.



Schizophrenia and Bipolar: Lower Prevalence, Severe Individual Impact



DALYs per 100,000 | Circle area is proportional to disease burden

Schizophrenia, while affecting fewer people, contributes 210.2 DALYs per 100,000 — reflecting severe disability. These conditions require sustained, specialized care even as resources scale for common disorders.

Treatment Is Available — But Often Lacking or Poor Quality

Mental illnesses are treatable and their impact can be reduced — yet significant barriers persist.



STIGMA

Many people are uncomfortable disclosing symptoms to healthcare professionals or even people they know.



ACCESS

Treatment is often lacking, especially in low- and middle-income countries.



QUALITY

Even where treatment exists, it may be of poor quality.



UNDERREPORTING

Discomfort with disclosure makes it difficult to estimate true prevalence — the actual burden may be higher.

Good data is essential — how, when, and why these conditions occur, and how they can be treated effectively and safely.

How People Cope: From Medication to Faith to Family Conversations

Global survey data reveals wide variation in how people deal with anxiety or depression.



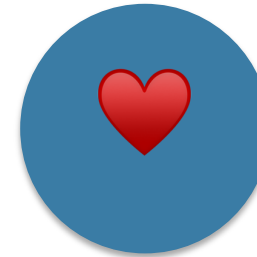
Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings where pharmaceutical access and healthcare infrastructure are stronger.



Religious or Spiritual Activities

Prevalent in many regions worldwide, reflecting the deep connection between faith and mental well-being.



Talking to Friends or Family

A widely reported coping mechanism across cultures, highlighting the role of social support networks.

Policy implication:

The diversity of coping strategies underscores that mental health responses are shaped by cultural, economic, and healthcare system factors. Interventions must account for these differences rather than applying a one-size-fits-all approach.

Key Takeaways for Policy Action

- 1 Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs — each ~690 per 100,000.
- 2 Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder carry disproportionately high individual burden relative to their prevalence.
- 3 Effective treatments exist, but access and quality remain grossly inadequate — especially in low- and middle-income countries.
- 4 Stigma suppresses both help-seeking and accurate data, meaning the true burden is likely underestimated.
- 5 Policy should prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common mental disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions.